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Lorraine Feather

Lorraine Feather is a lyricist, vocalist, and composer of distinctive jazz-tinged songs in the tradition of Jon Hendricks, Dave Frishberg, and Annie Ross. She has collaborated with Dick Hyman, Stephanie Trick, and with a number of notable film directors. Her father was the well-known jazz historian and author, Leonard Feather.

Lorraine was interviewed via Zoom on March 22, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and boy am I pleased to have Lorraine Feather with me this morning. Welcome. Thanks for your time.

LF: Thank you, Monk, for inviting me.

MR: I'm going to introduce you as a vocalist, a lyricist, a wordsmith, and I believe a very active, creative mind.

LF: Thank you. That's nice of you to say.

MR: Yeah.

LF: I always put lyricist first, because I could stop singing but never writing lyrics as long as able.

MR: I believe you did say in something I read that when you found out about being a lyricist and that you could do it —

LF: Yeah.

MR: That that was — I forget your exact words but that was the thing. That was going to be your thing.

LF: Did I use the word thunderbolt?

MR: Okay. That may have been it.

LF: Possibly. Yeah. It was really something. Do you want me to tell you how that happened?

MR: Sure.

LF: So I was in this vocal group called Full Swing that was put together by Richard Perry, at that time a huge pop producer, and Joel Silver, a big movie producer. And they had this idea to have an updated big band with three vocalists in front of it. So they hired me and Charlotte Crossley, who was in "Jesus Christ Superstar" with me and also was a Harlette with Bette Midler, and Steve March Torme, Mel Torme's son. So he was looking for songs for us to record. This is the first time I had an actual record deal so it was very exciting and Richard was living a glamorous life and he had Planet Records and Studio 55 — or was it Studio 54? No it was Studio 55. One of them was a nightclub. But so he

hear Tommy Newsom's big band. We heard this song called "La Bem" that Tommy had written, and then we had a meeting with Richard and he said, "I want to have lyrics to that song. I think we should hire a lyricist." And for some reason I said, "I could do it." I hadn't really written lyrics all that much. I had made some attempts at writing kind of quasi-pop songs when I was in my late 20s. I was 32 at the time of this meeting. But I had grown up listening to Lambert, Hendricks & Ross and trying to sing along with my mom. So I knew what it was to write complicated words to complicated pieces of music, and it just seemed like something that would be fun to try. So I said, "Well I can do it." And I went oh, okay. I went home, I wrote lyrics to this Tommy Newsom piece and I brought them back and I sang it through for Richard and the other two, and they were kind of quiet. And he said, "Well I don't like it at all. It should be completely different. It should be about —" this, this, this and that, and I was furiously scribbling away. So I went home and re-did it, brought it back, he said, "Yeah I like it. We'll record that." And I wound up writing lyrics for half the album but it just came so naturally to me, not that it was easy but it was so organic. It was easier than singing, it was easier than anything I've ever tried to do before — dancing which I attempted for many years, acting which I love but never made much of a splash at, and it just took over my life from that point onward, I loved it so much.

MR: Can you tell me the name of the tune again, the Tommy Newsom tune?

LF: The title was "The Trocadero Ballroom." It was like the opera, La B-O-E — no actually it was something else it was a play on words that was not the same as the opera but it was something like La Boheme. And then my title was "The Trocadero Ballroom" 'cause Richard said, "It should be about a ballroom and everybody wants to go there and it's very glamorous, they're doing cocaine — mind you, it was the 80s so that's —

MR: Do you recall if your mother or if your father explained — tried to explain to you what Jon Hendricks and others were doing when they took those melodies that people had improvised and wrote lyrics. Did you understand that at that point?

LF: No. I was never told what they did. It just was. It was just something that my mom and I used to try and sing along to with not very much success like Jackie. There's the song about the mouse, the Annie Ross song, and everything. It was just so much fun. And I remember meeting Jon many times. He was a Virgo like me, he always used to bring that up. And I saw him perform — I saw him with Yolande Bavan who came after Annie Ross as you know. And it was just — it was just part of my musical life. It was some of the first music I ever glommed on to and thought was fun.

MR: I love that vision. Like you know your classmates might have been singing [sings] Lollipop, Lollipop oh Lolli Lollipop, and you're singing Lambert, Hendricks & Ross.

LF: [Sings] The more I'm with you pretty baby. That's "Centerpiece." That was one of their slow tunes.

MR: Yes. You know what Jon Hendricks called your father?

LF: "Learned Father?"

MR: He told me "Learned Father," yes that's right.

LF: Yeah, that's right. I had kind of forgotten that but when you brought up Jon then I realized — and he asked me if I would like to be in his group, a later version of his group, many, many years later but it was just — it was driving around the country in a car and it was him and me and Judith and I think one of the participants, the singers, was going to be Bruce Scott who did sing with my vocal group for a while. He was really good at all that Lambert, Hendricks & Ross stuff. But yeah, I just — I never really thought about it but I heard nothing but that kind of music for years and years, Dinah Washington and of course Billie Holiday, Peggy Lee was my mom's ex-roommate and friend. And it was just — it was just part of my life. The people who used to call the house were Willie "The Lion" Smith and he always introduced himself as, "Hello this is Willie 'The Lion' Smith. Can I speak to your dad?" And I was eight. I thought he was a real lion at the time.

MR: Lion King.

LF: Yeah he was. And Andy Razaf, the great lyricist who wrote with Fats Waller.

MR: You moved to Los Angeles and then you returned to New York. Do you recall if your parents were supportive of your intentions for a career in music?

LF: Well at the time I was trying to have a career in theater because I had — I started taking dance lessons when I was 12. My mom, I think she was under the impression that it was cotillion or something, that I was going to make friends and meet people. And it wasn't like that. It was a jazz dance class led by this guy Carlton Johnson who is fantastic. He's not with us anymore but they had a conga player for the exercises and then they would play Motown music and I got totally smitten and started taking class constantly. I really didn't have the body for dance and I started too late. But then that shifted. I went to a Catholic girls' school for just one year because my friend was going there, Jeri Southern's daughter Kathryn King. And I didn't particularly care for it, but they were doing an all-girl production of "Electra" the Greek tragedy. The lead got sick and I said, "I can do it" — sort of like saying I could write lyrics, "I think I could do it" because I was pretty good at, very good at memorizing mostly. And so I did it. I played the part and I can't imagine that I was very good but my class all stood up at the end. And I'd been sort of shy and dorky and didn't really consider myself a popular girl but it was exciting being on stage and being part of this story. So I thought well that's what I'm going to do. I'm going to go to New York and be an actress. So I switched over to Hollywood High

award for some little competition. And then at 18 — well actually 17, I got a little scholarship to study at Circle in the Square, a theater in New York. And then I stayed on when I was 18 and got a waitress job, my friend joined me and got a waitress job and I proceeded to waitress a lot and occasionally I would get into a show. But your original question was do you recall how your parents felt about it?

MR: Correct.

LF: That was five minutes ago, I know. But yes, they were rather upset. They didn't expect me to leave California like that and it was just upsetting to them that I was so far away and, you know, you're going to be a cocktail waitress? You're going to be dating musicians and running wild all over New York? All of which was true of course. And I did get in "Jesus Christ Superstar" at one point. I did it on the road and I did it on Broadway. I was in a tour, I was in the original theater thing, but mostly I just waitressed a lot, something that I was not good at particularly. When I was in my mid-20s I got a job singing back-up for Grand Funk Railroad.

MR: Oh. [sings] We're an American band.

LF: Yeah. So that was really fun. I was a Funkette.

MR: You were a Funkette.

LF: Yeah. In fishnet hose and a leotard and everything.

MR: How did those vocal parts get worked out? How many back-up singers were there?

LF: Just two.

MR: Just two, so you sort of did it by ear or did you have a producer involved?

LF: I think we just did it by ear. The other gig I had in that period of time was with Petula Clark in Vegas. And somehow or other I got this job. Oh what happened was I had been waiting around for this acting audition for a showcase that paid nothing. There was a line around the block. And all of a sudden I just went, "I can't take this anymore." I had been singing in clubs a little bit, and I went home to my then-boyfriend and I said, "I'm not an actress anymore, okay? I'm a singer. I can't take it, I just can't. So I've been making some grocery money singing and I'm going to sing now." So magically, a week or so later I got this awesome call to sing with Petula Clark in Vegas for a couple of weeks and wear beautiful outfits and be with an orchestra. But the thing is that they — one of the other singers who, "I don't really have time to help you through the parts, I'm going to send you all the sheet music." And I don't read. I don't read music at all. I could tell you what key something is in by looking at the sharps or flats, but I don't read. So we got up there and there was a rehearsal and there was the orchestra and the two other women who'd been with Petula for ages, and I just followed along with them, like a millisecond behind the other singers until I'd memorized the parts. And Petula came up and said, "Oh

MR: Aw that's sweet.

LF: Yeah. She was very sweet.

MR: There's one song of hers that just — I love so much, it's called "I Couldn't Live Without Your Love." And I just — I guess it's the chord progression or something. I appreciate arrangements. And you know she had good arrangements.

LF: Yeah, she did. It was all top flight. I liked "Don't Sleep in the Subway."

MR: Yeah.

LF: Yeah that was good.

MR: Well the leap from — you've made a few leaps. And before too much times goes by I want to ask you where your ideas come from. Because you've written everything from a song about bats in your apartment to this — I might as well just ask you about this song right now.

LF: Go ahead.

MR: I saw this song title and — "Hadron, Meson, Baryon"

LF: "Hadron, Meson, Baryon"

MR: Thank you. I knew I'd mispronounce that but I thought, "Oh that's interesting she wrote a song about a law firm." So you know I did some digging and where did the idea to write about subatomic particles come from?

LF: I don't know where these ideas come from sometimes but I had — I was reading this book by Walter Isaacson, a terrific writer, *Einstein: His Life and Universe*. And I was thinking of this episode of "Frasier" my ex-husband used to play in the warm-up band for "Frasier" because it was done live. And there was a scene in which Frasier was going on a tropical vacation and his family was there and his latest girlfriend was there, and Frasier is just being a real jerk. He's complaining about everything. And the girlfriend says, "Come on Frasier, can't you just relax? Can't you just have fun?" And he says, "Fun? Fun was my middle name in math camp." So I did a little digging and I found out that math camp is a thing, and that you have to take a qualifying quiz. I don't know anything about physics, I just thought I wanted to do an album called "Math Camp." And so I went to various websites like Electromagnetism for Dummies and so forth, and I just picked up certain little words and phrases that I thought were cool. And the way that I wrote "Hadron, Meson, Baryon" was that I saw an article that I think it was in "The Atlantic" reprinted from "Quanta" magazine. But it was called "A Fight for the Soul of Science" and it had a photo of all of these physicists at a conference and the lead guy is older and he's got his head in his hands like as if in despair. And the idea was that they, these people had thought maybe they should just team up with philosophers to try and figure out how it all started because the search to go ever smaller, smaller, smaller, smaller, and

dollars. So they were just in despair. And then I saw these names of the elementary particles and I thought it was "mayson" too but I looked it up, Hadron, Meson, Baryon. And I thought well that's kind of a hooky little — that would make a good hook. Hadron, Meson, Baryon. So I created a little story about a class of people who are in despair and they're wondering what's at the bottom of it all and the physicist in the story is a woman and she goes back and she's with her husband. And you know it's just — writing lyrics is so much fun, like I said well they should have a dog. There are more animals in my songs than normal I know. What kind of a dog would it be? And I picked out a Maltese mix, a mix, 'cause I like to support the rescue efforts. But it just — and from there it's hard to say, it just kind of evolved or blossomed.

MR: Well it's pure poetry. I'm going to read a — I'm going to test your memory, I'm going to read a phrase and I'm going to ask you to answer with the appropriate phrase.

LF: I'll try.

MR: Okay. "To pick the lock that guards the place"

LF: "Of dark and light of time and space" or something like that?

MR: Correct. "That I could" — no I'm sorry – "Where an answer might be found."

LF: "That I could wrap my head around."

MR: That's right.

LF: No one's ever quizzed me in an interview before.

MR: You get to move on to the next round. But you know I had this really odd image because about the time I was looking into this song, and I downloaded the piano music about the same time I passed by one of these big white boards that are in Hamilton just on the walls where students study. And it had that typical, either it was chemistry or it was physics or something, you know the black — I mean the whole board like this unending calculation. And then I looked at Eddie Arkin's chord changes and I'm going to read just four of them.

LF: Okay.

MR: A flat minor 6–9 major seven, G 13 sharp 9, G flat 13 flat 9, F minor 6-9 add 11 in a measure of 3/2. These are chord changes but they also might be the secret of life, I don't know.

LF: Yeah. He'll appreciate that.

MR: So how does that come about? When you have a song like this and you write the lyrics, are you already singing it and establishing a melody when you get together with a pianist that you have for them, and you're going to sing it to them? Is that a fair assessment?

LF: Well it doesn't work that way exactly. I used to write lyrics to existing music at the beginning — old music, Fats Waller, Duke Ellington. That's what I did for several

almost always I come up with a lyric idea first and I bring it to them. It's a little different with every guy. With Russell Ferrante I might — I often will send a little phone memo of me speaking to a metronome the phrasing to the whole song. But it's just — it's different with everybody. But usually, like with Eddie, he's — Russell is a virtuosic pianist of course. Eddie is a great guitar player but we usually write on piano. So it used to be that I would always go over to his home studio and he would say, "Well I have an idea for the beginning" and he'd play some changes and we'd try out some melodies on my voice. And then sometimes he'd throw it out but I'd go, "Ooh what was that change?" 'Cause I — like those chord changes that you named, I wouldn't know what any of them sounded like but I know what I like. And so we just kind of work through it that way. But we've known each other for 35 years now so we can do it on the phone pretty much. I saw him, I saw them all a week ago in L.A. and it was just fantastic. But we had already been tossing things back and forth remotely for a long time, you know when you get to know somebody so well that way. And in almost every case it's lyrics first. And I might have a template like I'll say, "Well what about this — I was listening to this Bach fugue when I was writing this" or this Astor Piazzolla piece or this Scott Joplin piece, and then they'll, that might spark an idea of something around the same tempo. But it never sounds like, you know, a sound alike at all.

MR: Talking about writing on the phone it reminds me of anecdotes I've heard about Ellington and Strayhorn that kind of the symbiotic relationship they had.

LF: Yeah. Yeah it's similar. I mean Eddie jokes because I've been writing recently — well like for the last — with him, Russell, Shelly, Dave Grusin — and he said, "You're like our mutual muse" because most of those guys just at this point had not been writing songs necessarily but it's a thing that we do together that, you know.

MR: That producer way back with Tommy Newsom was not at all afraid to tell you that, no I don't like that. And are you able to say that to these pianists and accompanists, that no I don't like that?

LF: Well I wouldn't use those words. Gee I don't know because they all have such a vast trove of harmonies and melodies at their disposal. And a lot of the time they're not sure either. And if they want to tell me they don't like something they can, or, more often it might be something very simple like, "I think this song is too long, I think that we need to repeat this phrase" — it's just some kind of a technical issue. And we might change our minds of course.

MR: There was an interesting moment in your tune, "I Love You Guys" where I think it was just the first two lines that you sang. The piano was playing the melody with you and I wondered, I don't know if it was planned or was it spontaneous but it was a nice effect

LF: Yes. I had forgotten, but you're right. It is a nice effect that we use sometimes. And I might sing in unison with Charlie Bisharat, the violinist, or with the pianist, in that case it was Shelly. He — I know that at the beginning of that tune he wanted it to be about journeymen musicians who are doing all these gigs and a lot of them were horrible. And he wanted to sound like he was kind of in a lounge overplaying. But we had a lot of fun. I really like it. Oh and then there's a line in "I Love You Guys", "I love it when you take it 'round the bend together then you suddenly and mysteriously end together — and Shelly said it should just be complete chaos and then all of a sudden you suddenly mysteriously end together. And everybody got a kick out of that because it's part of their lives. So you know, and I also put a thing in there about a seven-stroke roll — your license plate — I've dated a ton of you, married one of you, his license plate was a seven-stroke roll. That was just a little nod to my husband of almost 30 years, Tony Morales. Although I believe my ex-brother-in-law is the one who has the seven-stroke roll on his license plate. But it's an inside drummer thing that most people wouldn't know but I like to make the guys laugh.

MR: That's an interesting thing to think about inside. Have you ever listened — had your music playing with a small group of people and you're there and some of these lyric things you do come up. Do you watch these people to see if they're sort of chuckling at the parts that you hope they chuckle to?

LF: Oh yeah. Yeah. I haven't been performing in some time because I've been more focused on writing lyrics and doing my own projects, but yes, I notice that in the audience. And you have to think about whether or not you want to put a little interlude after something that you consider funny, just so that the beginning of the next line doesn't get drowned in laughter.

MR: Wow. Almost like a comedian.

LF: Almost like a comedian.

MR: The recordings I've listened to are — I'll relate another thing I remember reading. Milt Hinton, the bassist, talking about recording sessions with Dinah Washington and the quartet would get there ahead of time and sort of run through the tunes and then she'd walk in and say, "Okay what have we got?" And she would do one take and consider it done. So this long intro to my question is how do your arrangements occur, which are quite precise at times?

LF: Well the composers are the arrangers and some of what they do is very precise and meant to be played as written. And then there are other spots that are left loose because they know the personality of the people who are going to be on the session in most cases. And they want that person to be able to play a little solo or to do something that has a certain

MR: Are you in a booth singing with the group usually? Or do you sometimes sing after the fact?

LF: Well I mean I have sung along many times with them but I consider it like, it's not a natural process so to speak. It's like making a film, you put the pieces together and I generally sing after the fact but of course I do a lot of vocal harmonies that often I will record the vocal, the pads, the vocal harmonies that I'm singing with myself ahead of time and also I do these talking sections as you've noticed probably, and I'll do that ahead of time too because when the band comes in to play it brings them into the atmosphere of the tune kind of. Like the harmonies are such a big part of the feeling of the story that I discovered that it's nice to do them first. And it's also nice to do them first for me singing the lead.

MR: Are you a person who has trouble knowing when things are done?

LF: Yeah.

MR: Either your own lyrics or a recording?

LF: My own lyrics not so much. I pretty well know that they're done although what happens is that I never just sit down and hammer away until something is done. I'll have an idea and then once I'm in the head of writing the song, the lyrics, it flows through my consciousness all the time and things come up, I'll find little internal rhymes and rhythms, alliteration and just words that I want to use instead of other words, but once I finish it it's pretty much done. I'm not rigid about it but singing wise I do have trouble knowing when it's done. Like I'll go like I don't really like the way I sang. Like, "No it's fine, Lorraine." But I" — "No, it's fine." Once I was doing this album called "Tales of the Unusual" and I wrote lyrics to Nino Rota's "Juliet of the Spirits" thing called "Rose Aurata." Russell arranged it for me. It's mostly in harmony and then there's this little one talking part where it's a woman in the circus and she says, "Look at all the people out there tonight, darling, I think we have a full house. I'm so excited." I was working at the time with Carlos Rosario, the engineer/producer who did a lot of my albums and he's wonderful. And every time we listened to that back he'd laugh. He says, "It's just so funny the way you said it." I said, "Well let me do it again." And he went, "No, I refuse to let you do it again." So yeah, I'm not sure a lot of the time if I'm done or not vocally.

MR: Yeah. The collaboration you did with Stephanie Trick was pretty amazing. Is there any plans for more of that?

LF: Well no, not right now. And I miss Stephanie a great deal. Performing with her was just fantastic. We had a multi-media thing going that her late father had put together with lyrics on a screen and then there's a little cam on Stephanie's flying fingers. And we had a video and various pictures of James P. Johnson, Fats Waller. But that was a moment in

we thought it would be good to do a gig and then we said well let's do an album. And I had used up so many Fats Waller tunes on my own Fats album that we tried to concentrate on James P. Johnson. But Stephanie, who was — I always forget how old she is — but she looked like she was 12 at the time I was working with her, she was so young. But she knew all of this old James P. Johnson stuff and Willie "The Lion" Smith and some other composers I'd never heard of. There was a guy named Robin Frost who wrote something called — I think it was Robin Frost — "Greased Limelight" that, it was written to be played by computer because it was pretty much unplayable. But Stephanie played it. And I wrote lyrics to it and called it, "Let's Do This." So she was just this amazing trove of information about music — I mean Fats Waller died before even I was born and Stephanie just — she was just created to do this. So we did the album and we did some gigs together that were super fun. I would say it was maybe the most entertaining musical performance I've ever been part of. And her husband, Paolo, is a an — Alderighi — is a fantastic player, and then they would do a thing together. It was just like huge fun. It's very hard to remember all those lyrics. I really don't drink at all anymore but at the time I did, but never before that show. Because it's intense remembering all of it. But yeah, I'm just crazy about her and I would like to work with her again, perform with her again.

MR: Wow. That's sort of a specialized genre but over the years can you articulate what makes for a valuable piano accompanist?

LF: Well because I do songs that were already arranged by the composers it's not necessarily an issue because the usual answer to that would be someone who doesn't overplay, someone who doesn't rush. But I play, have performed almost exclusively with the guys who wrote the music. So it just doesn't come up. With Russell, with Shelly and with Stephanie of course. So it's completely natural. It's difficult to do it with another person. Songs that I might not think are terribly difficult somebody, I tried to do them with players that everyone said oh this is the best guy in such-and-such town. And it would be someone who is great but he'd go like, "This song is just almost impossible to pull off I don't know if I can do it." So it's kind of challenging.

MR: Are you mostly pleased with what jazz critics write about your work and you? I'm going to give you one that just — I spotted in a review in "Jazz Times." "Intellectual jazz lab dedicated to the dissection of the human condition."

LF: Was that for "Math Camp?"

MR: Yes.

LF: Sounds like a "Math Camp" review. Yeah that's fine. Yeah that's okay. You know I mean nobody likes getting slammed but you know for the most part I've had some very

interesting things said about me. My favorites are by people who are not critics like Dave Frishberg and Alan Bergman. But yeah, I can see that. Sure.

MR: You seem to be very attuned to good grammar and punctuation and — why?

LF: Why?

MR: I mean that's, everybody should be, right?

LF: Well my father, basically.

MR: From your father. Uh huh.

LF: That's the short answer, my father. I remember when I was waitressing he said that it's crème de manthe not crème de menthe — I said, "Daddy, that's not the way the other waitresses pronounce it." And he said, "And you should say langerie not lingerie. Why that came up I don't remember. But nobody says langerie, an English speaker. And he was — he was an expert in the English language and that was the only subject I was ever good at in school, really. I was terrible at history, geography, chemistry. But I loved diagramming sentences. And I'm not saying that my grammar is perfect, my English is perfect, it's not. I mean have you ever discovered that you've been mispronouncing a word for your entire life?

MR: I did like Hardon, Bason and whatever that other one was.

LF: That one, yeah. Well I found out that the word E-S-C-H-E-U apparently is pronounced "eschew." I always thought it was askew. Like A-S-K —

MR: As did I.

LF: You did?

MR: Yes, of course.

LF: Well we both have to look it up just to double check. But I'm pretty sure it's not askew. But yeah, I got that from my dad and I'm happy that we had that in common. He called me once, this is shortly after I got married and he was laughing so hard he almost couldn't talk, he said, "Lorraine I saw this anec — I won't tell you who the actor was — this interview with a TV actor in TV Guide and he said he had taken up directing and he said, 'One day I was sitting at my desk and I felt the desire to act literally drain through my fingertips.' Literally."

MR: I can see how that would get to your father.

LF: It did.

MR: You know I have his — in case you notice, I have his early book strategically placed over my shoulder.

LF: Oh, nice.

MR: Yeah.

LF: I can't see them but thank you for showing me.

MR: Yeah that was a gift for me, I think a high school graduation. And when I look at it now it's really lovely to read and it's quaint because he included addresses of people.

LF: Right. I remember when he was putting that encyclopedia together he and Ira Gitler, it was this massive dining room table we had that my parents kept for decades. And all these biographies were strewn all over. It was quite an undertaking considering that these musicians were all over the world, some of them were not very good about getting back to him for one reason or another, and it's really kind of amazing that he did it and got as much information as he did.

MR: Yes and it's informative to read now. What he chose to write about people back then, in the 60s, and we know them now from their whole career after that but we sometimes forget what they did when they were young men and women.

LF: Yeah. Yeah well it's so magical in a way, the way my dad arrived on the scene exactly when he did because everything was happening. And he was friends with Charlie Parker. I have — I'm staring across the room at my dad's book *Inside Bebop* framed, and it's autographed "To Leonard, my best friend, Charlie Parker."

MR: I'm not sure how to phrase this question but I'll give it a try.

LF: Yeah?

MR: The fact that he was British, correct?

LF: Yeah.

MR: Do you think that some of the African-American musicians thought of him differently even though he's white but he was British, that maybe he didn't bring any of the prejudice that was so apparent at that time?

LF: Yeah. That's a good question, and I believe they did think of him differently for that reason. He was first entranced with jazz when he listened to "West End Blues," Louis Armstrong — Louis Armstrong's "West End Blues" in London. And then when he came over to the States and he was able to meet him he was just so bowled over that these people he admired treated him with such friendliness and he was shocked. I don't know what the situation was at the time in London, but my dad was horrified at the racial prejudice in the States and became active in the NAACP when I was I think in my teens, but it just — it was horrible. And it was such a short time ago, you know? Just awful. So yeah I think that they might have trusted him a little bit more.

MR: Did you become aware — when did you become aware that your name had significance? I'll just leave it at that. What they chose to name you.

LF: Oh my first name — Billie Jane Lee Lorraine — well I was called Billie or Billie Jane for the first few years of my life and for some reason I think I didn't like Billie and Feather together. And I said, "I want you to call me Lorraine." They gave me four names.

written to this person's dad way back in the day saying that there were a lot of arguments about my name and that's why they wound up giving me four. But it was, you know, Billie for Billie Holiday. When my mother was pregnant Billie Holiday said, "Oh I want to be the Godmother" so of course they wanted to have that connection. And they called me Billie. Jane for my mom, Lee for Peggy Lee, and Lorraine for the song "Sweet Lorraine." So I guess it just dawned on me slowly why they called me all those things. But I've been Lorraine for a very long time. There are a few people who call me Billie but almost nobody.

MR: Have you ever thought about trying to write a lyric about that?

LF: No.

MR: Well I think you should think about it.

LF: Okay. I'll put it on my long, long list.

MR: A long, long list. Like the long list you waited in that made you decide to not be an actress anymore.

LF: A line around the block and it paid nothing.

MR: Oh. That's paying some dues right there.

LF: Oh yeah.

MR: Have you ever thought about being political in your lyrics?

LF: No. I could, I have strong views, but it just for some reason didn't seem like a good fit. There are other people who do great political satire and I don't know, it just didn't ever come into my head as a compelling thing to do.

MR: Sometimes those kind of lyrics don't date well either.

LF: Right.

MR: It's like your song now has a short shelf life so to speak.

LF: Yeah who was it who did Haldeman, Ehrlichman, Mitchell and Dean/follows a pattern if you dig what I mean? Who was that?

MR: Oh, you stumped the band.

LF: H2O-gate Blues or something?

MR: Oh okay. On your website there's sort of a blog about Miss English and her Pet Peeves.

LF: Oh.

MR: Yes. It's very fun reading.

LF: Well I haven't updated it in a long time because I feel as if maybe it is dated. I know so many people now who are upset at apostrophes being used to pluralize. Somebody posted about it on FaceBook just the other day. I forget what kind of a store it was but let's say it was Waymans and then it said, you know, couch's, chair's, table's — each with an apostrophe. And they didn't use an apostrophe for the possessive of the actual name of

Store and I complained internally about it for many years, not having an apostrophe. And then I found out that the founder's name was something like Edward Ralphs. So you never know. Yeah, Miss English, there are just — I don't know there are so many people who are aware of that. But I have a couple of musicals that I have worked on with Nan Schwartz, the wonderful composer in L.A. and one of them is called "The Grammarians." It's based on a novel by Cathleen Schine about two identical twins who are obsessed with grammar. So I hope that we can finish that sometime because I really like writing songs about grammar.

MR: If you had a blank check, sort of following up on what you just said, what's your dream — do you have a dream project that someone else funds?

LF: A blank check? You mean like even a hundred million dollars would be okay?

MR: Well that's a pretty large check, maybe just —

LF: I need to know. I need to know because I do have a project in mind but it might be pretty expensive, maybe 50 million. Well let's — can we not put a dollar amount on it?

MR: Sure. Blank.

LF: Okay. An animated jazz musical. That would be my dream. And I could use all the incredible singers and musicians I know. And I'd sing on it too but that wouldn't be the main point. And I could write things with my co-writers, I could also use some old music — the Fats Waller and Duke Ellington things I've done with lyrics or do some more. You'd have to put aside some money for a legal team because the rights to those things are always a little bit difficult to attain. But yeah, that would be my absolute dream.

MR: All right. I'll keep my eye out for some funding for that. Let me run a couple names by you that I believe you've worked with. Dick Hyman?

LF: Oh. Well Dick Hyman was my parents' friend when we were back in New York. I knew him a little bit, Dick and Julia. But when I was living in northern California and my dad had passed away and I was going through a lot of CDs and re-issues in the garage to help my mom decide what to donate. And I came across this Fats Waller double CD called "Turn on the Heat." And I just absolutely fell in love with it. My parents hadn't played much stride music because it was too old fashioned for them. But I just loved it. I used to drive around in my Volkswagen Beetle with a CD changer, listen to it over and over and over again. And I was writing at this time lyrics for cartoons. But I wasn't employed at the time and I thought I want to do something kind of challenging and fun. So I wrote lyrics to something called "Smashing Thirds" and titled it "Cezanne," — or actually it had a different title at the time, it was called "No for an Answer" because it was about how everyone gave the painter Cezanne, they all told him no until he was, you know, pretty much dead. And I sent it to Dick Hyman because he is the stride guy and I thought

Waller sample. So Dick Hyman calls me up, and mind you I really didn't know him at all except just vaguely. And he said, "All right," he said, "you have to do a whole album of these stride piano pieces with your lyrics because who else is going to do it? And I like it because," he said, "it's like Lambert, Hendricks & Ross only the music is much older, even much older" he said, and I'll plan it. But I don't have time right now so find somebody else and then when it's time" — and he began sending me all of these stride pieces, and I just kept going. And about two weeks after this my mom passed away and Dick called again and he said, "You need something to do right now, just keep working on the album." So I worked with Mike Lang, who sadly, I mean Dick Hyman at 96 still sounded great when I talked to him a few weeks ago. Mike Lang, the pianist in L.A. who was helping me on some of this has sadly died. But he kind of got me started and then I went to Florida and finished up with Dick. And we did a few gigs together. But it was just incredible because he just kind of told me to do it. And I thought it would be fun so I did it.

MR: Wow. What a story.

LF: Yeah.

MR: He's something else. He's capable of just about anything I guess.

LF: And he's so modest. He's funny and dignified and wry and just one of the most admirable people I've ever met.

MR: How about Bela Fleck?

LF: I don't know Bela Fleck. I heard something of his. I was just looking around on Amazon for music when I was writing this album called "Ages" and I heard a tune of his called "Circus of Regrets" I believe it was. I got in touch with him. Somehow or other I wrote words to it and called it "Peculiar Universe." And I made a little recording of it in my home studio, Tony's and my home studio, and sent it to him and whoever it was who manages him said, "Well he usually doesn't agree to things like that." But he said yes. And I asked him if he'd play on it, which he did while he was on the road. And it was on my "Ages" album. But I've never — I've seen him perform, I love him, but I've never actually met him.

MR: That's so interesting this day and age, I guess that's like exchange of sound files.

LF: Yeah.

MR: Right?

LF: Yeah. That's right.

MR: Gee. How do you charge for your work? If you are writing lyrics for a cartoon or some Disney thing, there's the musician's union, is there a lyricist's union?

LF: No, sadly there is not. I have an agent in the U.K., Maggie Rockford and if something

Beatty movie "Rules Don't Apply" which is named after a song after we wrote it. It was unfortunately a terrible flop. But it was exciting to do and at the time we made a deal to write it and also I had recorded the song and they had an option to use my version but they decided just to leave Lily Collins' version as the closing title. So yeah, it's just a thing that somebody negotiates for you if you have someone to do that, which I do.

MR: Are you an optimist?

LF: Yeah. I am. I think I've said many times I believe the best part of life can come at any moment.

MR: Nice. And when we wrap this up, do you have a project that you will turn to that's sort of in the works?

LF: I have a couple of things in the works. Well I'm doing a new album which is called "The Green World" and I have about half of the songs almost done, not recorded but written. And I'm working on something that — I shouldn't say the title yet because I'm not entirely sure, but Bill Elliot, who used to have a big band when I was in L.A. and has written a couple of songs with me, was working with the soprano, conductor Barbara Hannigan who is this extraordinary eccentric woman who sings opera and conducts. She won the Gramophone Award for Artist of the Year last year. And Bill was going to London to record an adaptation he did of John Lithgow's book "The Remarkable Farkle McBride" re-titled "The Remarkable Sparkle McBride" for Barbara. And he had room for something else so he said maybe we should write something. And actually no what happened was I called him and I said, "Are you still working with Barbara Hannigan?" Because a mutual friend of ours had said you and Bill should write something for Barbara. And I happened to call him exactly as he was sort of thinking about that. So we wrote a 15-minute piece based on Catherine Manfield's short story "Bliss" which is about a young woman who falls in love with another woman in her social circle. It's got a surprise ending. It's very dramatic, was perfectly suited for an opera, and we recorded it and videotaped it with the BBC orchestra and Barbara conducting and singing. And it came off really well, so we're working on something else, Bill and I. And those are my two main projects right now, although there are some others kind of in the wings too.

MR: Do you have a work pattern? I've often read, talking about authors and composers, that you have to have a routine, you have to write something every day even if you have no particular impetus or inspiration, you just have to keep writing. Do you find that is true?

LF: Not exactly. There are days when I don't write. But if I have songs in progress I like to go visit them on any given day and maybe change a thing or two. I'm not super disciplined that way. I start in the morning — if I begin a song in the morning, a lyric, I can work on it into the night but I would never, almost never, start anything at night or in

begin writing a lyric. But then if I go out walking or when I used to have a garden if I'm outside gardening it just — it just, yeah, sort of courses through my mind the whole time. And that's how it happens. I don't consider it like a real job, although on any given day I might get up and go okay, I'm going to work on such-and-such today and I'll just do it all day long. Or if for example Eddie and I are working on the title tune for the Green World album, we'll call and we'll talk through something and we'll figure out a little section and we'll try out certain things on my voice. Or we'll work on harmonies. And then he'll go, "Okay I'm going to program this so I'll call you back." And I'll go okay, I'll go have a sandwich or talk to my cat or do any other thing. And then it just goes on and off all day. So I wouldn't say I have a schedule but I don't let months go by without writing, ever. Like I can't do that.

MR: Do you walk around your apartment reading your lyrics, trying them out?

LF: Yeah, I do. I sing through them a lot. Sometimes I put on my noise-canceling headphones and I'll sing through something with one ear slightly off, and that's what happens when I'm working on an album. I sing through everything constantly until I'm done.

MR: Nice. To wrap up, I'm wondering if your parents lived long enough to see your path come to fruition?

LF: My dad came to some gigs at which I was doing all my own songs. And he got a huge kick out of it because people would come up to him and say, "Oh Leonard, the apple doesn't fall far from the tree." He was a huge supporter of my lyric writing ambitions and in fact when he was in the hospital in Encino Tarzana Hospital and very sick, I remember him saying, "Did you send Cleo Laine your Ellington re-dos? Because she's doing an Ellington album with Mercer Ellington. Did you send them to her?" And I was able to go, "Yes. She got back to me, she's recording a couple of them." He cared a lot about my writing and we went to ASCAP meetings together. He was very proud of me. But when I got my first Grammy nomination I cried a bit because I wished they could have seen that. It would have been exciting even though my dad had something of a jaundiced view of awards and ceremonies. But he would have been so proud.

MR: Excellent. Well congratulations on your career, and this has been a really fascinating conversation.

LF: Oh for me too.

MR: Thank you.

LF: [inaudible] never to quiz me.

MR: So yeah, I'll just pause here and we'll say our good-byes.

LF: Okay.

MR: Thanks again.